PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #6 · CONFIDENCE WITH PEOPLE · SAFER TO STAY AWAY

“Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Do you steer clear of social situations, new jobs, or new activities because you fear embarrassment or criticism? Do you feel safer staying on the sidelines? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward trying again, and to find the courage that comes from knowing God’s word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

Repeated criticism, teasing, shaming, or being left out can teach a person that other people are a source of pain. A child who was often corrected harshly, compared with others, or humiliated may learn that staying quiet and out of view is the best way to stay safe. Over time, avoiding feels like wisdom rather than fear.

How the belief can keep itself going

Avoiding gives quick relief, and relief makes avoiding feel like the right choice. But the person never learns that most situations are survivable or that people are often kinder than expected. Skills stay unpracticed, opportunities pass, and loneliness grows, which can seem to confirm the original fear. Small steps, taken gradually, let us gather new evidence.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is honest about fear and does not shame us for it. The Lord says over and over, “Do not fear,” and ties that command to His presence and help. The fear of other people can become a snare, but trusting the Lord sets us securely. These passages do not call us to be reckless. They remind us that we do not take each step alone.

> *“The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high.” (Proverbs 29:25)*

Also see

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness.” (Isaiah 41:10)

> “For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control.” (2 Timothy 1:7)

> “When I am afraid, I put my trust in You.” (Psalm 56:3)

> “Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.” (Joshua 1:9)

Common self-statements

- It is safer to stay home than to risk looking foolish.
- I will pass on that job or event; I would only embarrass myself.
- If I never try, I can never fail in front of anyone.
- I will wait until I feel confident before I join in.
- I would rather be alone than be judged.

• Why take the chance when I already know how it will go?

Common logical errors

• Fortune telling: Predicting that I will embarrass myself before I have tried.

• Catastrophizing: Treating a possible awkward moment as a disaster I could not survive.

• Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of dread as proof that the situation is dangerous.

• All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that if I cannot do it perfectly, I should not do it at all.

• Discounting the positive: Ignoring times when I took a risk and it turned out fine.

• Overestimating the cost: Believing others will notice and remember my mistakes far more than they do.

Challenging questions

• What exactly am I afraid will happen, and how likely is it?

• If it did happen, how bad would it really be, and could I cope with it?

• What is the cost of staying away, in friendships, work, and joy?

• Has avoiding ever made the fear smaller in the long run, or larger?

• Can I recall a time I took a small risk and it went better than I expected?

• What is one very small step I could take this week, with God's help?

• If a friend described this fear, what would I encourage them to do?

Truth summary

Feeling afraid is not the same as being in danger. Avoiding gives short-term relief but keeps the fear alive and shrinks my life. I can take small, manageable steps and learn from what actually happens. Embarrassment is uncomfortable, but I can survive it, and God is with me in every step.

A short prayer

Lord, You know how heavy this fear feels. Be my security when I want to hide. Give me courage for one small step today, and remind me that I am never alone. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

• Fear

• Trust

• Strength

• Loneliness

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

• Anxiety, Worry, Fear

• Self-Esteem, Low

• Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Trust in God
Elevation Worship feat. Chris Brown

Reflect on trusting God when stepping out feels risky.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Remember God's goodness in each small step you take.

No Longer Slaves
Jonathan David & Melissa Helser

Practice replacing fear with the confidence that you belong to God.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Let your identity rest in who God says you are.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call avoidant personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Avoiding feared situations is the most common way anxiety is maintained; gradual exposure is a central treatment for social anxiety and for avoidant patterns, and it can occur with depression, trauma, or other conditions. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Gradual exposure should be paced to the person; anyone with severe anxiety, depression, or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What is one small step I can take today instead of avoiding?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment."

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you feel like staying away.

- ☐ What exactly am I afraid will happen, and how likely is it?
- ☐ If it did happen, how bad would it really be, and could I cope with it?
- ☐ What is the cost of staying away, in friendships, work, and joy?
- ☐ Has avoiding ever made the fear smaller in the long run, or larger?
- ☐ Can I recall a time I took a small risk and it went better than I expected?
- ☐ What is one very small step I could take this week, with God's help?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Feeling afraid is not the same as being in danger.
- ☐ I can take small steps and learn from what really happens.
- ☐ Avoiding helps for a moment, but it keeps the fear going.
- ☐ I can survive embarrassment, and I can grow from it.
- ☐ I do not have to feel confident first; I can act while still nervous.
- ☐ God is with me, so I do not face each step alone.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Proverbs 29:25
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- ☐ 2 Timothy 1:7
  "For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control."

- [ ] Psalm 56:3
  "When I am afraid, I put my trust in You."
- [ ] Joshua 1:9
  "Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Fear. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Choose one small, low-risk social step this week, such as greeting a neighbor or sending a short message. Predict what will happen, then record what did.
- ☐ Say yes to one small invitation or activity you would normally decline. Stay for a set short time, then notice how it went.
- ☐ Ask a question or share a short opinion in a group, then rate how bad it actually was from 0 to 10.
- ☐ Try one new activity alone in public, such as a class, a library visit, or a walk in a busy place. Note what you feared and what happened.
- ☐ Make a “fear ladder” of five situations from easiest to hardest and do the easiest one. Repeat it until it feels easier.
- ☐ Write an honest prayer about what scares you, then choose one small step to take today.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about courage, trust, and taking small steps with God.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Avoiding people and new challenges is safer than risking embarrassment.~~

NEW TRUTH:
Fear is not danger. I can take small steps, learn from what happens, and trust that God is with me.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Proverbs 29:25

A short prayer

Lord, thank You that You are with me. Give me courage for small steps, patience with myself, and trust that I am safe in Your care. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #7 · CONFIDENCE WITH PEOPLE · LESS THAN OTHERS

"I am inadequate and less than other people."

✦ ✦ ✦

Do you often feel that you fall short and that everyone else is more capable, interesting, or worthy than you are? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward seeing yourself as God sees you, and to find the confidence that comes from knowing His word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

Harsh criticism, constant comparison with a sibling or classmate, being rejected, or growing up without encouragement can plant the idea that we are not enough. A child cannot easily separate "what happened to me" from "who I am," so the feeling can settle in as a belief about identity.

How the belief can keep itself going

Comparing ourselves with others' best moments makes us look smaller. We may stay quiet to avoid being noticed, then read our silence as proof that we have little to offer. We discount compliments and magnify mistakes. Looking for evidence that does not fit the belief can begin to loosen it.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture teaches that our worth does not come from comparison or performance. God made each person with care, calls us His workmanship, and makes us complete in Christ. Where we feel weak, His strength is not blocked but displayed. These passages speak about our value in God's eyes; they do not say we have no growing to do.

> *"I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well." (Psalm 139:14)*

Also see

> "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life." (Ephesians 2:10)

> "And you have been made complete in Christ, who is the head over every ruler and authority." (Colossians 2:10)

> "Not that we are competent in ourselves to claim that anything comes from us, but our competence comes from God." (2 Corinthians 3:5)

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me." (2 Corinthians 12:9)

Common self-statements

- Everyone else seems to have it together except me.
- I am not as smart, interesting, or capable as other people.
- I do not belong here.
- Other people are simply better than I am.
- I will never measure up.
- If they only knew how ordinary I am, they would lose interest.

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Measuring my inner struggles against other people's outward appearance.
- Global labeling: Turning "I made a mistake" into "I am inadequate."
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing compliments and successes as luck or politeness.
- Mental filter: Noticing my flaws while overlooking my strengths.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of being "less than" as proof that I am.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I must be outstanding or I am worthless.

Challenging questions

- Where did I first learn that I was not enough, and who said it?
- What would I say to a friend who described themselves this way?
- What are three things I do well or that others have appreciated in me?
- Am I comparing my whole self to someone else's highlight?
- What does God say about my value, and does it depend on my performance?
- Is it fair to judge my whole worth by one weakness or one failure?
- What is one strength I could use this week?

Truth summary

I am not less than others. My worth does not rise and fall with comparison; it comes from God, who made me with care and loves me. I have strengths and weaknesses like everyone, and my weaknesses do not cancel my value. In Christ I am complete, and I can grow without being ashamed of where I am now.

A short prayer

Father, thank You for making me on purpose. When I feel less than, remind me that my worth rests in You. Help me see the gifts You have given me and receive Your love today. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love, by God
- Guilt and Shame
- Strength

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Let your identity rest in who God says you are.

Known
Tauren Wells

Consider being fully known and fully loved.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Practice bringing yourself to God just as you are.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Remember God's goodness toward you, not your performance.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call avoidant personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. A persistent sense of being less than others is common in depression, social anxiety, and low self-esteem, and often develops from early criticism or comparison. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Gradual exposure should be paced to the person; anyone with severe anxiety, depression, or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What does God say about me today, and what is one thing I can do well?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I am inadequate and less than other people."

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "I am inadequate and less than other people." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you feel less than others.

- ☐ Where did I first learn that I was not enough, and who said it?
- ☐ What would I say to a friend who described themselves this way?
- ☐ What are three things I do well or that others have appreciated in me?
- ☐ Am I comparing my whole self to someone else's highlight?
- ☐ What does God say about my value, and does it depend on my performance?
- ☐ Is it fair to judge my whole worth by one weakness or one failure?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ I am not less than others; my worth comes from God.
- ☐ I have both strengths and weaknesses, like everyone.
- ☐ One mistake does not make me inadequate.
- ☐ Comparison gives me a distorted picture.
- ☐ I am complete in Christ and can grow without shame.
- ☐ I can receive a compliment and say thank you.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Psalm 139:14
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ Ephesians 2:10
  "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life."
- ☐ Colossians 2:10
  "And you have been made complete in Christ, who is the head over every ruler and authority."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 3:5
  "Not that we are competent in ourselves to claim that anything comes from us, but our competence comes from God."

☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9
"But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Self-Esteem, Low. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Write down three strengths and one kind thing someone has said about you. Read them each morning this week.
- ☐ Each time you compare yourself with someone, write one thing you do well that they may not.
- ☐ Accept one compliment this week by simply saying “Thank you,” without explaining it away.
- ☐ Ask a trusted friend what they appreciate about you. Compare their answer with your prediction.
- ☐ Do one task you do well and notice how you feel afterward.
- ☐ Write a short prayer thanking God for one way He made you.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about identity and worth in God's eyes.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~I am inadequate and less than other people.~~

NEW TRUTH:
I am not less than others. I am made by God, loved by Him, and complete in Christ.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Psalm 139:14

A short prayer

Lord, thank You for making me and for loving me. Help me see myself as You see me and to accept Your love today. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #8 · CONFIDENCE WITH PEOPLE · POOR SOCIAL SELF-IMAGE

“I am awkward and unlikable, and I have little to offer.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Are you hard on yourself about your personality and social skills? Do you assume that others find you dull, awkward, or unappealing? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward a kinder, truer view of yourself, and to find the encouragement that comes from knowing God’s word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

Being teased, ignored, or told “you’re too quiet” or “you’re too much” can teach a person to distrust their own personality. Shyness or a few awkward moments can be remembered vividly and turned into a verdict. Growing up without chances to practice friendships can also leave a person unsure of themselves.

How the belief can keep itself going

When we expect to be disliked, we watch ourselves closely, which makes conversation harder. We read neutral faces as bored or unimpressed and replay every awkward moment afterward. We may then avoid people, which leaves less practice and fewer good experiences. Shifting attention outward, to the other person, often helps.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture describes the body of Christ as many different parts, each needed, including those that seem weaker. God gives every person gifts to serve others, and He is not impressed by outward appearance. These passages speak to our value and our contribution; they do not say that social skills cannot be learned and strengthened.

> *“On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable.” (1 Corinthians 12:22)*

Also see

> “As good stewards of the manifold grace of God, each of you should use whatever gift he has received to serve one another.” (1 Peter 4:10)

> “Just as each of us has one body with many members, and not all members have the same function.” (Romans 12:4)

> “But the LORD said to Samuel, ‘Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.’” (1 Samuel 16:7)

> “For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother’s womb.” (Psalm 139:13)

Common self-statements

- I never know what to say.
- I am boring.
- People are just being polite when they talk to me.
- There is something wrong with my personality.
- I have nothing interesting to add.
- I am not the kind of person people want to be around.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming others find me dull without asking or checking.
- Spotlight effect: Believing others notice and remember my awkward moments far more than they do.
- Mental filter: Replaying one stumble and forgetting the conversations that went fine.
- Global labeling: Turning “I felt awkward” into “I am awkward.”
- Discounting the positive: Explaining away friendliness as mere politeness.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unlikable and concluding that I must be.

Challenging questions

- What evidence do I have that people dislike me, and what evidence goes the other way?
- Has anyone ever enjoyed my company, thanked me, or asked to see me again?
- How would I judge someone else who stumbled in a conversation?
- What would I tell a friend who described their personality this way?
- Do I notice others’ awkward moments as much as I notice my own?
- What gift or quality do I bring that I tend to overlook?
- What social skill could I practice a little at a time?

Truth summary

I am not defined by my shyness or my awkward moments. Everyone stumbles in conversation, and most people are focused on themselves. Social skills can be learned and strengthened with practice. God made me with a unique personality and gifts, and I have something real to offer.

A short prayer

Lord, You made me and You see my heart. Quiet the voice that says I am not enough. Help me move toward people with kindness, and use the gifts You have given me. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Friendship
- Church
- Loneliness

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
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Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

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Hillsong Worship

Let your identity rest in who God says you are.

Known
Tauren Wells

Consider being fully known and loved.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Practice coming as you are.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Remember God's goodness while you practice small steps.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call avoidant personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. A harsh view of one's social skills often reflects anxious self-monitoring rather than actual skill deficits; social skills can be practiced and strengthened, and the pattern can occur with social anxiety and depression. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Gradual exposure should be paced to the person; anyone with severe anxiety, depression, or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What is one kind thing I can offer someone today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I am awkward and unlikable, and I have little to offer."

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "I am awkward and unlikable, and I have little to offer." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you feel awkward or unlikable.

- ☐ What evidence do I have that people dislike me, and what evidence goes the other way?
- ☐ Has anyone ever enjoyed my company, thanked me, or asked to see me again?
- ☐ How would I judge someone else who stumbled in a conversation?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend who described their personality this way?
- ☐ Do I notice others' awkward moments as much as I notice my own?
- ☐ What gift or quality do I bring that I tend to overlook?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ One awkward moment does not describe my personality.
- ☐ Most people are focused on themselves, not on my slips.
- ☐ I can learn and practice social skills.
- ☐ I have gifts and qualities worth sharing.
- ☐ Someone enjoying my company is real, not just politeness.
- ☐ God made me on purpose, and I have something to offer.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 12:22
  "On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable."
- ☐ 1 Peter 4:10
  "As good stewards of the manifold grace of God, each of you should use whatever gift he has received to serve one another."
- ☐ Romans 12:4
  "Just as each of us has one body with many members, and not all members have the same function."
- ☐ 1 Samuel 16:7

"But the LORD said to Samuel, 'Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.'"

☐ Psalm 139:13
"For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Self-Esteem, Low. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Start one short, friendly conversation this week with a clerk, neighbor, or coworker. Record what you predicted and what happened.
- ☐ Ask someone a question about themselves and listen for two minutes. Notice how it feels to focus outward.
- ☐ Give one sincere compliment today and notice the response.
- ☐ Keep a list of good interactions this week, even small ones. Review it at the end.
- ☐ Join one small group or class and attend twice before deciding how it went.
- ☐ Write a prayer thanking God for one quality He gave you.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about identity and the gifts God has given me.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~I am awkward and unlikable, and I have little to offer.~~

NEW TRUTH:
One awkward moment is not my personality. God made me with gifts, and I have something to offer.

MY SCRIPTURE:
1 Corinthians 12:22

A short prayer

Lord, thank You for making me as I am. Help me move toward people with kindness and trust that I have something to give. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #9 · CONFIDENCE WITH PEOPLE · SAFE ONLY IF LIKED

"I must be sure people will like me before I let them know me."

✦ ✦ ✦

Do you wait until you are sure people will like you before you join in, open up, or let anyone see who you really are? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward letting others know you, and to find the freedom that comes from knowing God's word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

A person who was loved only when they performed well, or who was hurt after being open, may learn that acceptance must be earned first. Sharing something personal and being laughed at, or being betrayed, can lead to a rule: "Do not show myself until I know it is safe."

How the belief can keep itself going

Certainty about how others will respond is almost never possible, so the waiting never ends. Others may read our caution as coldness, and relationships stay on the surface. Closeness requires some risk, and without it we do not learn that we can be known and still accepted. Taking small, graded steps can help.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture tells us that God knows us completely and loves us anyway. Because He has accepted us in Christ, we are freed from the need to win everyone's approval. Perfect love casts out fear, and God invites us to accept one another as Christ accepted us. These passages do not say every person will respond kindly, only that our standing before God is secure.

> *"Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God." (Romans 15:7)*

Also see

> "O LORD, You have searched me and known me." (Psalm 139:1)

> "There is no fear in love, but perfect love drives out fear, because fear involves punishment. The one who fears has not been perfected in love." (1 John 4:18)

> "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ." (Galatians 1:10)

> "A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who stays closer than a brother." (Proverbs 18:24)

Common self-statements

- I will join in when I am sure they like me.
- I should not open up until I know it is safe.
- If I show who I am, they will leave.
- I have to be liked first.
- I cannot risk it without a guarantee.

- It is better to keep my distance than to be rejected.

Common logical errors

- Demanding certainty: Requiring a guarantee that is never available.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that people will reject the real me.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing people either fully accept me or completely reject me.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know what others think of me without checking.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of risk as proof of danger.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing times when someone accepted me.

Challenging questions

- Is it possible to be completely sure how someone will respond to me?
- What would I miss if I wait until I am certain?
- Has anyone ever liked me after getting to know me?
- What is the smallest, safest piece of myself I could share?
- Does my worth depend on whether this person likes me?
- How does God's knowledge of me, and His love, change my need for guarantees?
- What would a safe, trustworthy friend look like, and how would I know?

Truth summary

No one can be certain about how others will respond, and waiting for certainty keeps me from friendship. I can share a little at a time and see how people treat what I share. Not everyone will respond well, and that does not mean something is wrong with me. God already knows me and accepts me in Christ, so I can take small risks.

A short prayer

Father, You know me completely and love me still. When I want a guarantee before I connect, help me remember that Your acceptance is secure. Give me courage for a small, honest step today. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Friendship
- Love, by God
- Fear
- Loneliness

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Love
- Communication
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Known
Tauren Wells

Consider being fully known and loved.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Practice coming as you are.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Let your identity rest in who God says you are.

Trust in God
Elevation Worship feat. Chris Brown

Reflect on trusting God while taking small steps toward people.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call avoidant personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Requiring certainty of acceptance before engaging is a common safety behavior in social anxiety; it prevents the corrective experience of being known and accepted, and graded self-disclosure is a typical treatment step. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Gradual exposure should be paced to the person; anyone with severe anxiety, depression, or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What small piece of myself can I share with a safe person today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must be sure people will like me before I let them know me."

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "I must be sure people will like me before I let them know me." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you want a guarantee of being liked.

- ☐ Is it possible to be completely sure how someone will respond to me?
- ☐ What would I miss if I wait until I am certain?
- ☐ Has anyone ever liked me after getting to know me?
- ☐ What is the smallest, safest piece of myself I could share?
- ☐ Does my worth depend on whether this person likes me?
- ☐ How does God's knowledge of me, and His love, change my need for guarantees?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Certainty is not available, and waiting keeps me stuck.
- ☐ I can share a little at a time and see how people respond.
- ☐ My worth does not depend on one person's opinion.
- ☐ Not everyone will respond well, and that is not a verdict on me.
- ☐ God already knows me and accepts me in Christ.
- ☐ I can take a small risk with a safe person.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Romans 15:7
  "Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God."
- ☐ Psalm 139:1
  "O LORD, You have searched me and known me."
- ☐ 1 John 4:18
  "There is no fear in love, but perfect love drives out fear, because fear involves punishment. The one who fears has not been perfected in love."
- ☐ Galatians 1:10

“Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ.”

- [ ] Proverbs 18:24
“A man of many companions may come to ruin, but there is a friend who stays closer than a brother.”

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Friendship. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Share one small personal detail, such as a hobby or opinion, with a safe person this week. Predict their reaction, then record it.
- ☐ Respond to one invitation without first checking how everyone feels about you.
- ☐ Ask a friend for honest feedback on how they see you, then compare it with what you feared.
- ☐ Notice when you are waiting for a guarantee. Write the thought and take one small step anyway.
- ☐ Start or continue one conversation that goes a little beyond small talk.
- ☐ Write a prayer about wanting to be known, and take one small step toward a safe person.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about being known and loved.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~I must be sure people will like me before I let them know me.~~

NEW TRUTH:
I do not need a guarantee. I can share a little at a time, and God already knows and accepts me.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Romans 15:7

A short prayer

Lord, thank You that You know me and love me. Help me share a little of myself with safe people and trust You with the results. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.

PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #10 · CONFIDENCE WITH PEOPLE · FEAR OF SHAME

“Ridicule or criticism would prove I am worthless, and I could not bear it.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Do you dread being laughed at, criticized, or shamed, feeling that it would prove you are worthless and be more than you could bear? The information below is intended to help you take a step toward seeing that your worth is not decided by what others say, and to find the peace that comes from knowing God’s word as found in the Bible.

Where it often comes from

A person who was shamed in front of others, ridiculed at home or school, or humiliated for mistakes may come to dread it above almost anything. Early shaming can leave a lasting sense that exposure equals disgrace, so even mild criticism can feel like a blow to the whole self.

How the belief can keep itself going

When one criticism feels like proof of worthlessness, we stay away from anything that might invite it. Even in close relationships we hold back to avoid being seen in a weak moment. Because we never test the belief, we never find out that criticism is survivable and that it speaks about a behavior, not our whole worth. Learning to separate the two can be freeing.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture promises that those who trust in Christ will not be put to shame. Our standing before God does not depend on what others say about us, and Jesus Himself endured scorn and shame for us. There is no condemnation for those in Christ. These passages do not say people will never criticize us, but that their words do not define us.

> *“It is just as the Scripture says: ‘Anyone who believes in Him will never be put to shame.’” (Romans 10:11)*

Also see

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.” (Romans 8:1)

> “Do not be afraid, for you will not be put to shame; do not be intimidated, for you will not be humiliated. For you will forget the shame of your youth and will remember no more the reproach of your widowhood.” (Isaiah 54:4)

> “Let us fix our eyes on Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy set before Him endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.” (Hebrews 12:2)

> “Those who look to Him are radiant with joy; their faces shall never be ashamed.” (Psalm 34:5)

Common self-statements

- If they laugh at me, I will be crushed.
- One criticism proves what I have always feared about myself.
- I could not stand being humiliated.
- Being embarrassed would be the worst thing.
- If I fail in front of people, I will never recover.

- Criticism means I am worthless.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Treating embarrassment as unbearable rather than uncomfortable.
- Global labeling: Turning one criticism into "I am worthless."
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the sting of criticism as proof that I am bad.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either approved of or humiliated.
- Fortune telling: Predicting ridicule before it happens.
- Personalization: Assuming every critical remark is about my whole self.

Challenging questions

- When someone criticized me before, did I actually survive it?
- Does one person's criticism or laughter really determine my worth?
- Is it possible to feel embarrassed and still be a person of value?
- What is the difference between "I made a mistake" and "I am worthless"?
- How would I view someone else who was criticized in the same way?
- What does God say about shame, and about my standing before Him?
- How long would an embarrassing moment really last, and what would I do afterward?

Truth summary

Criticism can hurt, but it does not determine my worth. Embarrassment is painful, and I can bear it; it passes. My value is set by God, who has declared there is no condemnation for those in Christ. I can listen to useful feedback, let go of cruel words, and keep my place in His love.

A short prayer

Lord, You bore shame for me. When I fear ridicule, remind me that I am Yours and that no one's words can change Your love. Give me strength to face uncomfortable moments and peace afterward. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt and Shame
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Fear
- Love, by God

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Anxiety, Worry, Fear
- Forgive, Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Let your identity rest in who God says you are.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Practice bringing your shame to God.

Known
Tauren Wells

Consider being fully known and still loved.

Goodness of God
CeCe Winans

Remember God's goodness when others' words sting.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call avoidant personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Intense fear of shame and humiliation, with the belief that criticism confirms worthlessness, is common in social anxiety and depression and often traces to early shaming experiences; separating behavior from worth is a core cognitive step. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Gradual exposure should be paced to the person; anyone with severe anxiety, depression, or thoughts of self-harm should seek professional help.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What does God say about me, no matter what anyone else says?"

My Plan for Replacing "Ridicule or criticism would prove I am worthless, and I could not bear it."

✦ ✦ ✦

Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

> "Ridicule or criticism would prove I am worthless, and I could not bear it." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you fear being ridiculed.

- ☐ When someone criticized me before, did I actually survive it?
- ☐ Does one person's criticism or laughter really determine my worth?
- ☐ Is it possible to feel embarrassed and still be a person of value?
- ☐ What is the difference between "I made a mistake" and "I am worthless"?
- ☐ How would I view someone else who was criticized in the same way?
- ☐ What does God say about shame, and about my standing before Him?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ Criticism can hurt, but it does not determine my worth.
- ☐ Embarrassment is uncomfortable, and I can bear it.
- ☐ A mistake is not the same as being worthless.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for those in Christ.
- ☐ I can learn from fair feedback and let go of cruel words.
- ☐ My value comes from God, not from anyone's approval.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Romans 10:11
  "It is just as the Scripture says: 'Anyone who believes in Him will never be put to shame.'"
- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ Isaiah 54:4
  "Do not be afraid, for you will not be put to shame; do not be intimidated, for you will not be humiliated. For you will forget the shame of your youth and will remember no more the reproach of your widowhood."

- [ ] Hebrews 12:2
  "Let us fix our eyes on Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy set before Him endured the cross, scorning its shame, and sat down at the right hand of the throne of God."
- [ ] Psalm 34:5
  "Those who look to Him are radiant with joy; their faces shall never be ashamed."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Guilt and Shame. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ Recall one time you were embarrassed or criticized. Write how long it lasted, how you coped, and what happened afterward.
- ☐ Make one small, harmless mistake on purpose, such as a minor mispronunciation, and notice how others respond.
- ☐ When you receive criticism this week, write what was said, what part is useful, and what part is not about your worth.
- ☐ Ask a trusted person for one piece of honest feedback and practice listening without defending.
- ☐ Share a small imperfect effort, such as a draft or a new skill, with someone safe.
- ☐ Write a prayer giving your fear of shame to God, and read Romans 10:11 aloud.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about shame, worth, and God's acceptance.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~Ridicule or criticism would prove I am worthless, and I could not bear it.~~

NEW TRUTH:
Criticism does not determine my worth. I can bear embarrassment, and I belong to God.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Romans 10:11

A short prayer

Lord, thank You that I will not be put to shame in You. Help me face hard moments with courage and rest in Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.